

A PM's guide to
User Research





Agenda

1 Introduction

- Need for User Research
- Uncovering Problems
 - People problems
 - Jobs to be done
 - MOM's test

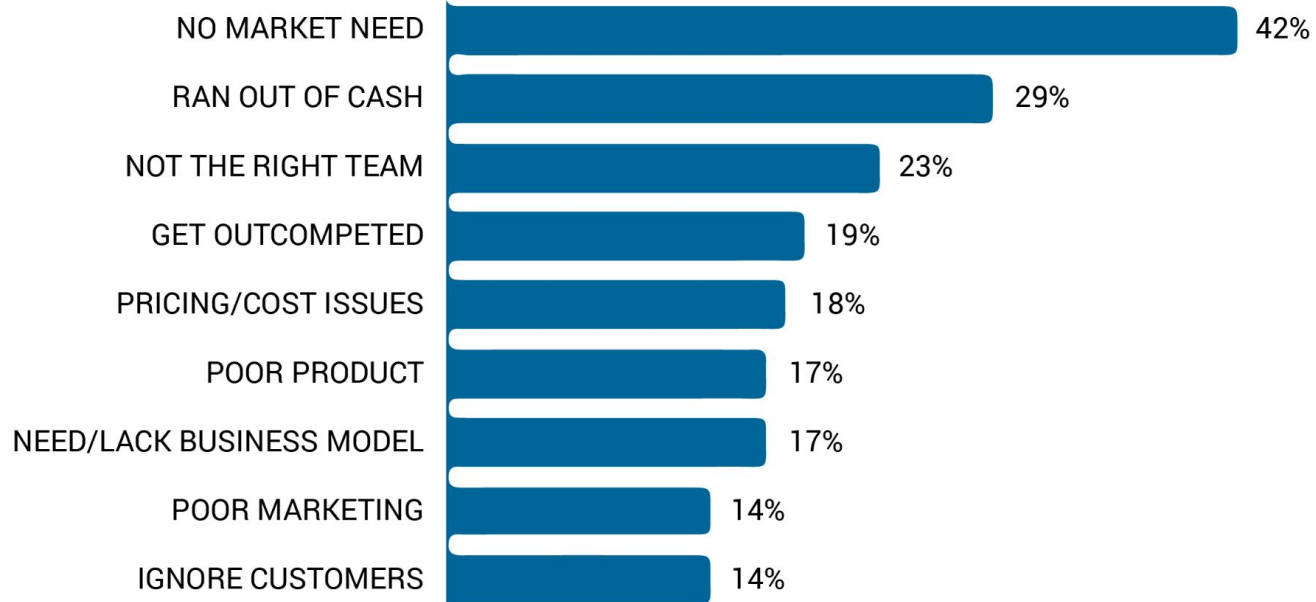
2 Conducting Research

- Finding the users
- The right questions
- Artefacts:
 - Personas
 - Empathy
 - Journey Maps

3 In Action

- Situational Examples
- Interview Questions
- Competitive Research
- Case Study

Top Reasons Why Startups Fail



“Products succeed
because they
address a desire or
solve a problem
in the life of the **user.**”



Uber

👉 Helps me get from A to B. With convenience of time, safety and predictability.

LinkedIn

👉 Helps me find people for jobs, opportunities or business.



ChatGPT

👉 Helps me answers questions to do my job well, quickly and saves time.

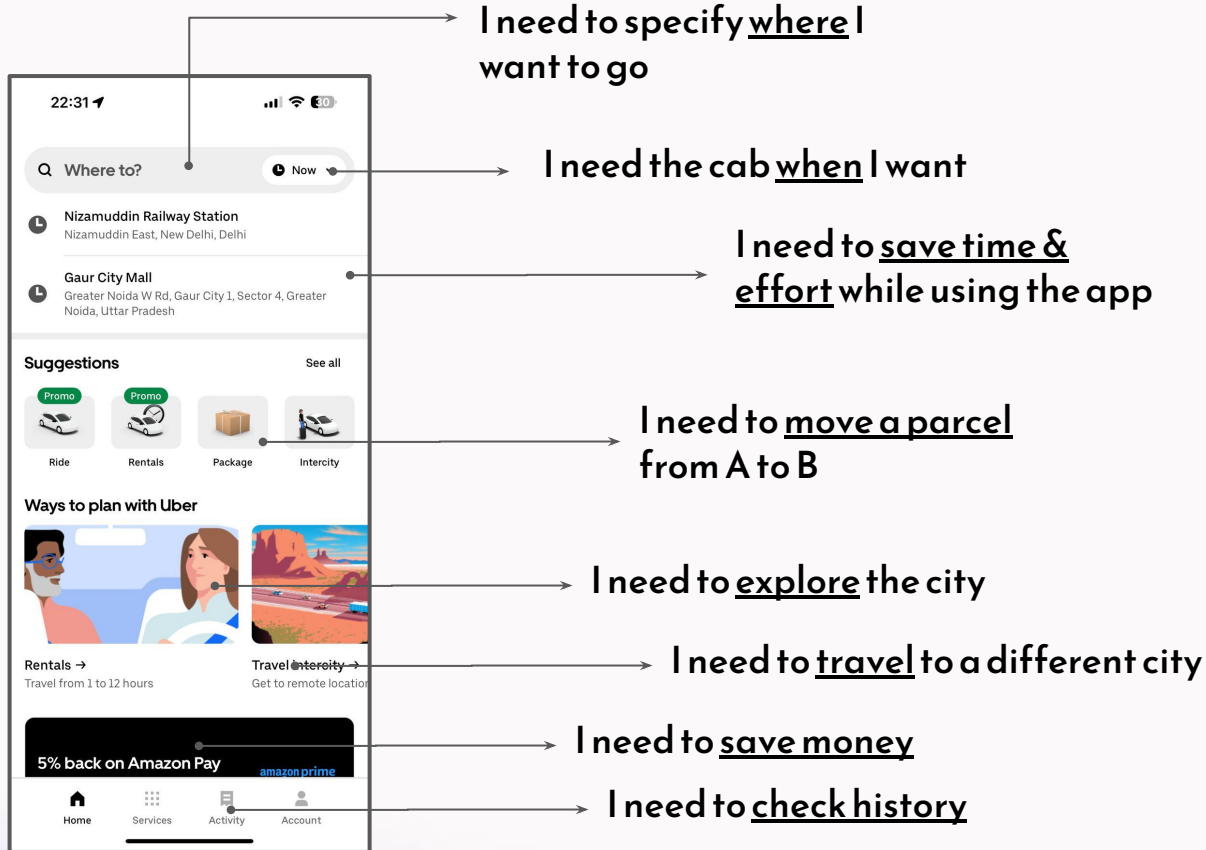


👉 Helps me keep my food for longer time.



👉 Helps me cover myself. Saves me from cold. Makes me look good.

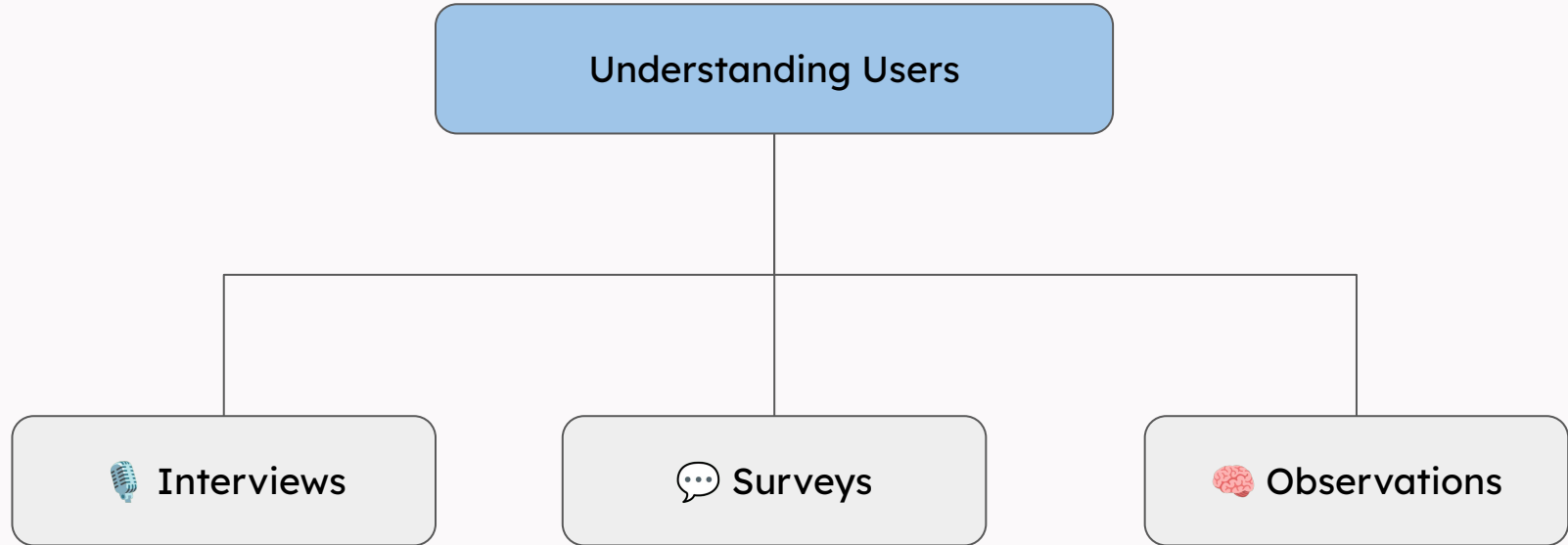
Uber 👉 Helps me get from A to B. With convenience of time, safety and predictability.



Major reasons why PMs fail at user research

- 1 **Acting on opinions rather than insights:** “User/Sales/Marketing/CEO told me build”
- 2 **Not talking frequently to the right users:** “Will talk only during big release”
- 3 **Don’t know how to ask questions:** “Do you like this feature?”
- 4 **Don’t know how to utilize user insights:** “I am doing interviews! Will share notes”

How to find users for research?



Understanding user problems/desires

Why do they want it? 👉 Why do they say this?

Why do they care about this? 👉 What is the people problem behind the product problem?

Go deep

Find the core needs 👉 Jobs to be done framework

Jobs to be done

Users are hiring your product **to do a job** for them **efficiently.**

People don't want a drill. They want a hole.

Actually they don't want a hole either, they want to relive the memory with the painting on the wall.

Jobs to be done

Job to be done	Option 1	Option 2
Find information about astrology	Go to the library	Search on Google
Incorporate a company	Ask a lawyer	Download a template online
Romantic night out	Go to watch a musical	Go to dance salsa

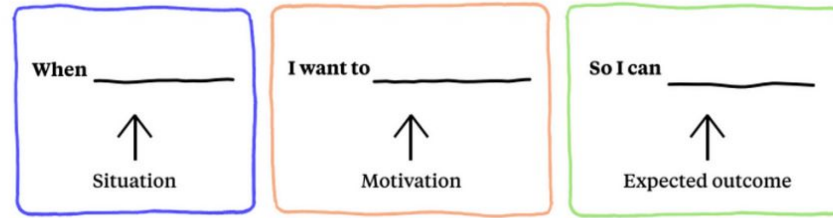
Types of JTBD

- **Functional** Job to be done
- **Emotional** Job to be done
- **Social** Job to be done

Jobs steps and variables

Functional Job: Go from New Delhi to Agra

Job steps	Variables
Decide on flight or train	Cost, Time Taken, Schedule Time, Importance of work, availability
Find a time to leave	Accuracy, availability, traffic
Find a vehicle to airport/station	Cost, Reliability, Time Taken, Safety
Get to right platform	Accuracy, Visibility, Reachability
Find the right seat	Accuracy, Availability, Visibility
Getting informed about journey	Accuracy, Availability



Music Streaming App 👉

"When I'm working out at the gym, I want to listen to high-energy music, so I can stay motivated and enjoy my workout."

Project Management Tool 👉

"When I'm managing a team project, I want to easily assign tasks and deadlines, so I can ensure the project is completed on time and nothing falls through the cracks."

E-Commerce Platform 👉

"When I'm shopping for clothes online, I want to see how the clothes look on models of my size, so I can make a better purchase decision."

Food Delivery App 👉

"When I'm too tired to cook after a long day of work, I want to order food from my favorite local restaurant, so I can relax and enjoy a good meal."

Best practices for user interviews

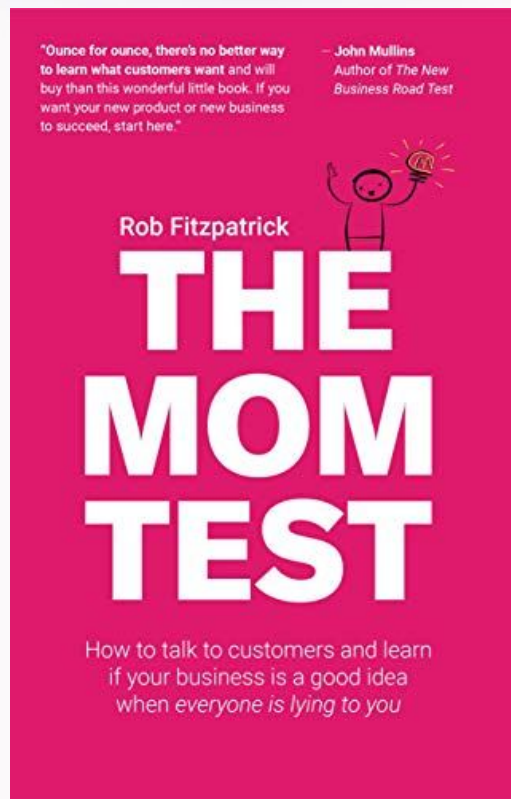
- ✅ Talk to the right users.
- 🎯 Be clear of your objectives.
- 📝 Have a list of exploratory questions.
- 🤝 Make them comfortable.
- 📌 Open ended: Do you like this? v/s What are your thoughts on this?
- 👂 Listen more, talk less. Avoid assumptions. Stay Neutral.
- 🧠 Clarify. Dig Deep. 5 Why.
- ✍️ Take Notes.

Actionables from The MOM's Test

- 1 Talk about **their life** instead of **your idea**.
- 2 Ask about specifics in the past, rather than opinions about the future.
- 3 Talk less, listen more.

Uncover problems through users.

Find solutions with your team, technology and market analogies



Actionables from The MOM's Test

Instead of This (Bad Questions)

"Do you think this is a good idea?"

"Would you buy a product that did X?"

"How much would you pay for this?"

"Would this feature be useful?"

Try This (Good Questions)

"Walk me through your current workflow for..."

"How are you currently solving this problem?"

"Have you tried to find a better solution? What did you find?"

"What's the hardest part about...?"

Observe



Artefacts

making your research usable





How to create user personas

Target audience segments (Who face the problem | Who uses your product)



Find frustrations, needs, behaviours and use-cases through user research



Group by similarities [Age, Occupation, Life Stage, Use Cases etc.]



Create Narratives

A persona is useless if it lives in a forgotten folder.

You must integrate it into your team's daily workflow.

1. **Introduce the Personas:** Hold a meeting with your entire team (engineering, design, marketing, etc.). Tell the story of each persona. Explain how they were created from real data.
2. **Make Them Visible:** Print them out and put them on the wall. Add them to your Confluence, Notion, or shared drive.
3. **Use Their Name in Every Conversation:**
 - **User Stories:** Instead of "As a user...", write "As Marketing Mary, I want to export my report to a PDF so I can share it with my boss."
 - **Prioritization:** During sprint planning, ask, "Which of these features will deliver the most value to Marketing Mary right now?"
 - **Design Reviews:** When looking at mockups, ask, "Would Developer Dave find this interface intuitive, or would he find it too simplistic?"



Aakash - The Product Guy

Age:

Tech Literacy:

Occupation:

Location:

Jobs to be done:

When (situation), I want to (job), so I can (expected outcome).

Bio 

Talk a little about your User here. What is this User currently doing and what things he prefers? This section can give a little more insight into the personality of the User help connect with them in a better way.

Core Needs 

- In this section, identify the main goals, tasks, or problems that the user wants to achieve or solve using the product or service.
- This includes their primary needs or use cases and the desired outcomes they expect from using the product.

Frustrations 

- The Frustrations/Pain Points section focuses on the challenges, difficulties, or pain points that the user experiences in their role or when trying to accomplish their goals.
- These frustrations highlight the areas where the product or service can address their needs and provide solutions or improvements.

Quote: This should be a concise sentence that sums up the one thing your user persona needs the most with regard to your app or website. Although it's made up, base the quote on your research, and imagine what your persona would say if they were a real person.



User Journey Map

HELLOPM.

Name of the Persona

Reason to Prioritize this persona

Phases

Change as per the use case

Signup

Onboarding

Browsing

Checkout

Post Purchase

Activity

What does the User do?

Thinking

What is the User thinking?

Experience

Change the emoji as per the User Experience



Unsure



Smiling/Excited



Stressed



Unhappy



Happy

Pain Points

Opportunity

Creating User Journey Maps

/Choose a Persona.

/Define Stages - eg: Awareness > Consideration > Purchase > Onboarding > Engagement > Retention.

/Gather Insights

/Open Miro/Figma/Spreadsheet

/Map User Actions and Touch Points

/Capture expectations

/Capture how they are feeling

/Highlight pain points and opportunities

/Validate and Iterate

User Journey

JOURNEY PHASES

Acquisition

Activation

Retention

Referral

ACTIONS

1. Discovers Notion from a colleague/ friend or through own research

2. Previews the product through job boards or colleague's account and decides to give it a try

3. Goes through onboarding process of setting up account and creating workspace

1. Scrolls through home screen to take a detailed look at all the features provided on the platform

2. Evaluates the features by comparing the templates and UX with similar platforms

3. Starts using Notion to organise tasks, projects and experimenting with templates/databases

1. Experiences boost in productivity as she becomes more familiar with Notion's functionalities

2. Actively collaborates with team and starts using Notion to track metrics

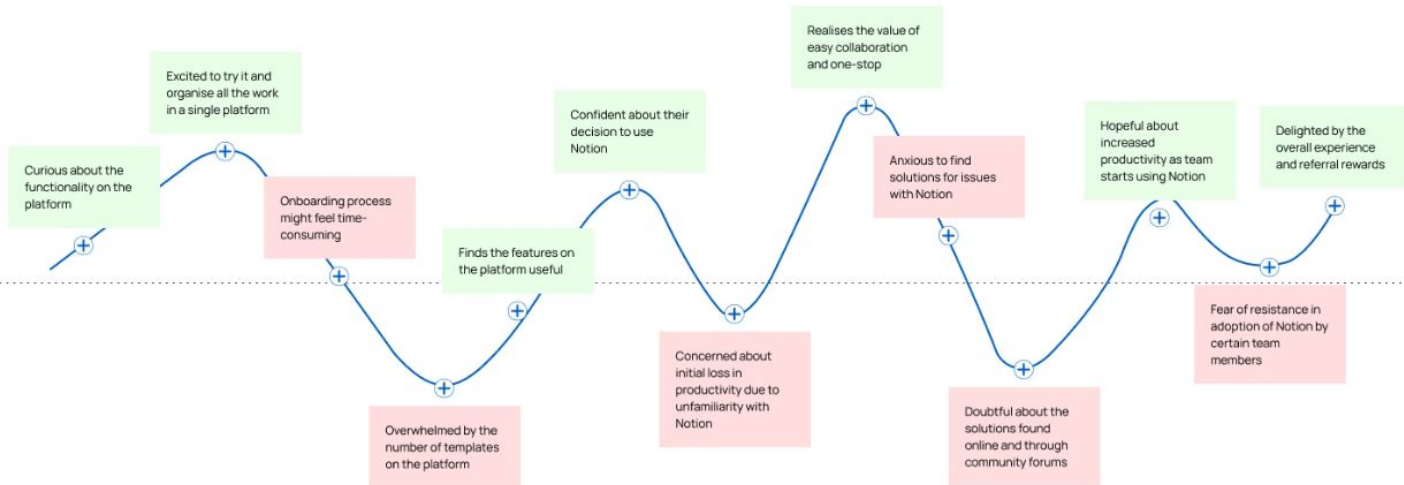
3. Seeks solutions to issues with Notion through online research or community forums

1. Continues using Notion as primary productivity tool and collaborating with her team

2. Recommends friends and other PMs to use Notion for improved productivity at work

3. Provides feedback to Notion team and tries out new features as the platform evolves

MINDSETS AND EMOTIONS





For you:

Create this prompt:

